Nehru has in mind, he should be entirely clear about it before we even consider our own decision."[278]

After the war, American officials indeed prepared to "head off" any British attempts to pull India into an alliance. When Soviet ambassador to the US Anatoly Dobrynin asked if the US had attached any conditions to aid, Averell Harriman, then assistant secretary of state for Far Eastern Affairs, speedily clarified that the US had not asked India to give up nonalignment.[279] Even when the US and India discussed an Air Defense Agreement months later, Rusk expected India to remain "unaligned" to try to obtain Soviet assistance against China. Furthermore, "It was not in our interests to 'compromise' Indian non-alignment, lest we promote a Soviet-Chinese rapprochement which would greatly up our bill."[280]

While the nature and extent of the alignment might be debated, there is little doubt that between 1956 and 1962 convergence on China created a US-India partnership. Contrary to most narratives, this development did not result from one individual (Kennedy) or one event (the 1962 war), but was part of a process of converging American and Indian perceptions of and policies toward China from just before the second Eisenhower term. This enhanced cooperation between the two countries, and made US-India differences that had previously been considered irreconcilable (such as over Pakistan and the Soviet Union) more manageable.